18

First Year of Kābul

Babur Departs from Ferghana

It was the month of Muḥarram in AD 1504. Babur had already left Ferghana and was headed towards Khurāsān. While on the way, he dismounted at Aīlāk-yīlāq, one of the summer pastures of Ḥiṣār. Babur turned twenty-three while staying in this camp. He has mentioned about applying a razor for the first time on his face.[1] Babur was accompanied by 300 people, who saw a ray of hope in him. These people were of varying ages, and each was ready to be in exile with Babur. Almost all of them were on foot and had walking staves in their hands, brogues on their feet, and long coats on their shoulders.

But poverty was the very nature of the whole camp including that of Babur. So insolvent they were that they had only two tents (*chādar*) in all. Babur's tent was used for his mother. They set an *ālāchūq*[2] at each stage for Babur to sit in.

Although they had started for Khurāsān, given the circumstances, they hoped for some respite from the land of Ḥiṣār through the Khusrau Shāh's retainers. Each day someone from the country, a tribe or the Moghūl horde would talk about hope from Babur. Around that period, Mullā Bābā of Pashāghar returned, who had been Babur's envoy to Khusrau Shāh. But he didn't bring anything from Khusrau Shāh that could please Babur and his men. However, he did bring enough pleasing things from the tribes and the horde.

After three or four marches beyond Aīlāk, they halted at a place near Ḥiṣār and called Khwāja 'Imād. However, Muḥibb-'alī the Armourer appeared instead. He came to Babur from Khusrau Shāh. Perhaps, Babur had felt very bad while passing through the territory of Khusrau Shāh. Reflecting upon the same, he has written in the *Baburnama*, 'Through Khusrau Shāh's territories, I twice happened to pass, renowned though he was for kindness and liberality, he neither time showed me the humanity he had shown to the meanest of men.'

Babur was expecting and hoping to gain something very handsome from the country and the tribes. Accordingly, he kept delaying the journey at each stage.